

Toddler Positive Phase — Action Checklist

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SHIFT YOUR MENTAL FRAME

- ☐ **Recognize that toddlers process "don't" as the very action you are forbidding, not a command to stop, because their prefrontal cortex is still under construction and they live in the present moment.:** Recognize that toddlers process "don't" as the very action you are forbidding, not a command to stop, because their prefrontal cortex is still under construction and they live in the present moment.
- ☐ **Stop interpreting your toddler's behavior as intentional defiance — it is a neurological response to language, not a personal attack on you.:** Stop interpreting your toddler's behavior as intentional defiance — it is a neurological response to language, not a personal attack on you.
- ☐ **Shift your internal script from expecting a fight to expecting normal development, because approaching interactions with tension causes your toddler to mirror and escalate that stress.:** Shift your internal script from expecting a fight to expecting normal development, because approaching interactions with tension causes your toddler to mirror and escalate that stress.
- ☐ **Focus on changing your words and environment rather than trying to become a perfectly calm parent, because sustainable change comes from the input you provide.:** Focus on changing your words and environment rather than trying to become a perfectly calm parent, because sustainable change comes from the input you provide.

USE POSITIVE REDIRECTION

- ☐ **Replace every negative command with a positive instruction by telling your toddler what to do instead of what to stop doing, using the three-part format:** instruction, brief reason, and alternative.
 - ☐ **Practice the "feet on the floor" phrase when your toddler climbs on furniture, saying "Feet on the floor. Chairs are for sitting" instead of "don't climb on that.":** Practice the "feet on the floor" phrase when your toddler climbs on furniture, saying "Feet on the floor. Chairs are for sitting" instead of "don't climb on that."
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- **Give a two-minute warning before transitions by saying "in two minutes, we will put the toys away," because sudden transitions are a common reason positive redirection fails.:** Give a two-minute warning before transitions by saying "in two minutes, we will put the toys away," because sudden transitions are a common reason positive redirection fails.
- **When your toddler does not respond to a redirection, check whether a basic need is unmet — hunger, tiredness, or overstimulation — and address that need first.:** When your toddler does not respond to a redirection, check whether a basic need is unmet — hunger, tiredness, or overstimulation — and address that need first.

DESIGN THE ENVIRONMENT

- **Designate one room, one corner, or a gated area as a "yes space" where everything is toddler-safe so you rarely need to say "no" at all.:** Designate one room, one corner, or a gated area as a "yes space" where everything is toddler-safe so you rarely need to say "no" at all.
- **Convert the yes space into a safe environment by covering all outlets, anchoring heavy furniture, removing small objects that could be swallowed, eliminating toxic items within reach, and placing a low shelf of accessible toys.:** Convert the yes space into a safe environment by covering all outlets, anchoring heavy furniture, removing small objects that could be swallowed, eliminating toxic items within reach, and placing a low shelf of accessible toys.
- **Give your toddler binary choices like "red shirt or blue shirt" or "walk to the car or be carried" to provide autonomy while keeping both options acceptable to you.:** Give your toddler binary choices like "red shirt or blue shirt" or "walk to the car or be carried" to provide autonomy while keeping both options acceptable to you.
- **Set up the environment so the need for corrections drops to nearly zero, because each "no" you say becomes a limit your toddler has to test and resist.:** Set up the environment so the need for corrections drops to nearly zero, because each "no" you say becomes a limit your toddler has to test and resist.